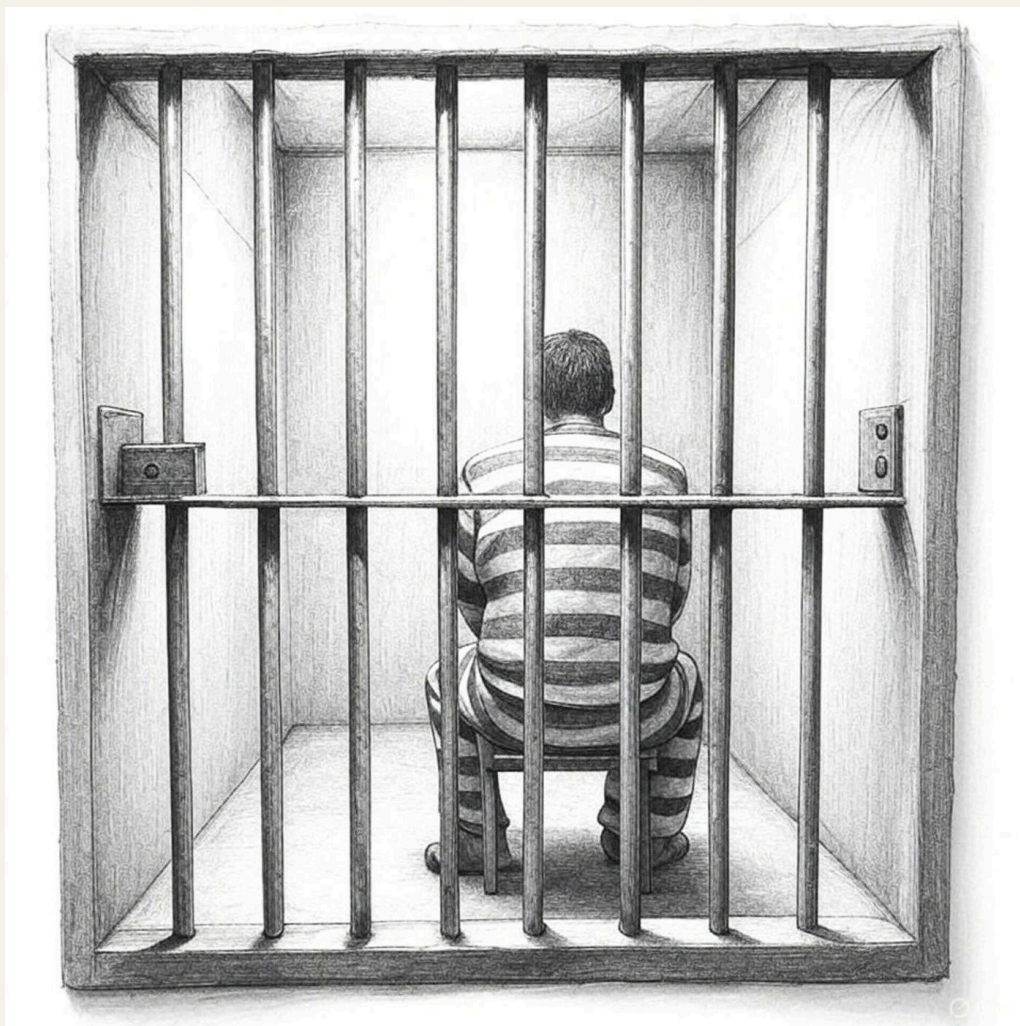


Condemnation



A man in prison stripes sits with his back to us. A bar locks the door. We are not watching a bad day. We are looking at a sentence.

Before you gather

- Read Day 9, Condemnation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 3:10, 13–14 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Name a courtroom scene from a movie. Did you agree with the verdict?

Leader. Keep it to fiction and one sentence. Then open Galatians 3. The real courtroom is God's. The curse is not a plot point. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Condemnation is a verdict, not a disappointment. Whoever does not believe is condemned already, and the pardon is Christ alone.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Condemnation is God's judicial verdict of guilt for sinners, resulting in the sentence of judgment and eternal separation from God. It is the opposite of justification.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek katakrima — a sentence of guilt, an adverse verdict.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 3:18

Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Condemnation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Galatians 3:10, 13–14

Galatians 3 shows the curse and the exchange. All who rely on works of the law are under a curse. Christ became a curse for us. Ask what the text says before anyone talks about how condemned they feel. Do not reteach the journal.

For all who rely on works of the law are under a curse; for it is written, “Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.” Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us — for it is written, “Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree” — so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, so that we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who is under the curse in verse 10, and what did Christ become in verse 13? CORE

Leader. Everyone who relies on law-keeping is under a curse, because the law requires all of it. Christ redeemed us by becoming a curse for us, hanged on a tree. The sentence moved onto the substitute. He was our substitute.

2. Verse 14 says what arrives on the other side of that exchange. What is it, besides a cleared record?

Leader. The blessing of Abraham comes to the Gentiles, and we receive the promised Spirit through faith. The way in is faith, not works. The door opens onto an inheritance, not onto a second chance to earn it.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. John 3:18 says whoever believes in the Son is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already. What do you say to a friend who thinks they are a decent person finding their own way?

Leader. Do not tell them they are already safe. The verdict is in. Evangelism is not 'become a better person.' It is 'you are condemned already, and there is a pardon in the name of the only Son of God.' Call them to believe.

4. Romans 8:33-34 asks who will bring a charge and who is to condemn. The answer is Christ, who died, was raised, and intercedes. Why is a living Jesus, not a forgiving feeling, the end of the case? **CORE**

Leader. The one who died and rose is the defense, at the right hand of God. The accuser cannot reopen what God has closed. Feelings of guilt are not the verdict. The risen Christ is. The Spirit leads by the Word (John 16:13; John 17:17).

5. Where do Christians still live as if the cell were locked, replaying a sin Christ has already borne?

Leader. Separate condemnation from conviction. The Spirit exposes sin to lead us to Christ (John 16:8). The accuser exposes sin to send us back to the cell. Romans 8:1 is for those in Christ Jesus. Do not read it over someone who has not believed.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Condemnation is God's guilty verdict. Jesus bore that curse for all who believe.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Do one concrete kindness for someone living under shame. Then say condemnation is a real guilty verdict, and Jesus bore it so that everyone who trusts Him would not carry it.

Leader. Do not tell them they are already safe if they have not trusted Christ. Offer Christ. A kindness that never names the substitute is not the whole challenge. Faith alone, not effort, is how the verdict changes. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord Jesus, thank You for becoming a curse for us on the tree.
2. We pray for people still condemned in John 3:18. Bring them to faith in Your name.
3. Silence accusation that pretends to be holiness, and keep us from calling unbelievers safe.

Before you stumble

Part II ends here. Next time is the manger. Do not skip ahead for fifteen minutes, and do not send the room home under the curse with no Christ. If you are short on time, the last word is Galatians 3:13. Never ask who has been in jail. The drawing is a verdict before God. If someone says decent people are fine, read John 3:18 again. Do not soften it. Do not tell unbelievers they are already safe.

WITH STUDENTS

'Condemned already' sounds harsh. Ask: if a doctor says the disease is already there, is that cruelty or clarity? Then ask what the cure is. Refuse any answer except faith in Christ. Do not tell an unbelieving student they are already safe.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 5:24. Whoever hears and believes has eternal life and does not come into judgment. He has passed from death to life. Leave the verse with them. It is for the one who believes, not for every person in the room by default.

